

The Box on the Sandbar: Motomachi's Forts, Fires and Foreign Consuls

A tombolo joining an island hill to the mainland, a box-shaped fort that gave the town its name, and a history of fire so relentless that the government once rewrote the street plan to stop it: this dossier follows Motomachi from a fifteenth-century stockade to the stone and brick townscape a visitor walks through today.



元町・ベイエリア（函館市）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1900 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A Fort Shaped Like a Box

Hakodate's 1911 district history describes the town's ground in three parts: a narrow, pinched sandbar in the middle, the isolated hill of Mount Hakodate holding up the southern end, and the flat Kameda plain opening out to the north. The Ainu name for the site was Usukeshi, which the same history explains as a corruption of Ushorokeshi, "the tip of the bay" — the same root, it notes, that gives the Iburi town of Usu its name. Mount Hakodate itself, an isolated andesite hill worn into the long, low silhouette of a lying-down ox, supplied the stone for Goryokaku's walls and much else besides; from 1897 the whole mountain was closed to civilians and turned over to army coastal artillery, which reshaped its summit with gun emplacements. The waterfront changed by engineering, not geology: harbor-improvement land reclaimed off the old Benten Point gun battery was completed in July 1899, adding five new districts, Shinhama, Daiba, Naka, Hokage and Kobune, to the town's edge.¹²

The town's own name is older than any of that. In 1454, according to both the city's own historical summary and a local museum register of cultural properties, a warrior named Kono Masamichi arrived from Tsugaru and built a fortified residence at Usukeshi, roughly 63 meters by 50 meters, ringed with earthen banks and dry moats. Because it was shaped like a box, people called it Hakodate — "box fort" — and wrote it 箱館. The site, in today's Yayoi-cho, stayed in continuous administrative use for four centuries: the Kameda magistrate's office moved there in 1741, the shogunate's own Hakodate magistracy in 1802. Only in 1869, when Ezo became Hokkaido, did the government swap the character 箱 for the similarly pronounced 函, giving the modern spelling 函館.¹⁵¹⁴

Guns on the Beach, Bells on the Hill

Matsumae-domain and shogunate control of the area brought its own anxieties, not least a Russian navy that had been probing the Kuril Islands and the Ezo coast since the early 1800s; in 1811 Japanese forces at Kunashiri seized the Russian surveying-ship captain Vasily Golovnin, and in the tangled hostage exchange that followed, the Hakodate merchant Takadaya Kahei was himself briefly seized and taken to Kamchatka before the two sides negotiated a settlement. By the 1850s it was American rather than Russian ships that worried the authorities: a surviving town proclamation, issued when a US squadron was expected off Hakodate, ordered women, children and anyone under thirteen out of the waterfront district into the hills, banned selling liquor to sailors on the grounds that "drink makes them violent," forbade townspeople from peering at the foreigners through shutters or chimneys, and told merchants to give foreigners whatever goods they asked for, declining any gift offered in return unless the giver insisted, rather than risk giving offence.²

Hakodate opened to foreign trade in 1859, one of the first ports Japan opened under its new commercial treaties, and consulates followed within the year. Russia's was among the first: its consul secured a plot on the hillside, and in 1860 a chapel was built there as the consulate's annex. A young priest named Nicholas arrived the following year as that chapel's chaplain; working from this hillside base he became the first missionary to establish Orthodox Christianity in Japan, before moving to Tokyo in 1872 to build a national church. The chapel he served in was rebuilt after fire in 1916 as the Church of the Resurrection that still stands on the hill, its bell — known locally as "Gan-gan-dera" — still ringing over Motomachi.¹¹

A Town That Kept Catching Fire

No account of Hakodate can avoid fire. A tally kept in the 1935 city history counts twenty-two fires of a hundred houses or more between 1873 and 1921 alone — one every two years and five months on average, and in the worst stretch, from 1907 to 1921, one every twenty months. One entry stands out for how it ties disaster to war: on 20 June 1869, fugitive shogunate soldiers under Enomoto Takeaki, cornered in the last weeks of the Boshin War, set fire to a lumberyard near Benten-cho, and the "fugitives' fire" burned 872 households. Two fires thirteen months apart then struck the growing town hard: 954 households burned on 16 November 1878, and on the night of 6 December 1879 a fire from Horie-cho burned through thirty-three neighborhoods and 2,326 households, including thirty-one public buildings; the 1935 history calls the second "unprecedented" and says the city seemed for a time to have simply vanished.²

It was the November 1878 fire that made Motomachi look the way it does today. On receiving the news, the Colonization Commission's director, Kuroda Kiyotaka, at once sent a senior secretary to Hakodate, and the ward's officials drew up a rebuilding code that Kuroda endorsed within days: the main thoroughfare was widened from roughly four ken to thirteen (about 24 meters), side streets to at least six ken, all laid dead straight, and — the crucial rule — buildings along the main street and along every road running from the hillside down to the shore had to be built of stone, brick or plastered earthen-walled dozo construction, fireproof by design. Loans subsidised those who could not afford it, the Yachigashira wetland was reclaimed as relocation land, and new quarries were opened on the mountain's back slope to supply the stone. Barely more than a year later the far larger December 1879 fire tested the same code before the rebuilding was even finished; the stone and brick streetscape visitors now photograph in Motomachi is, in large part, that disaster-recovery regulation made permanent.²

War's Last Stand and a Prefecture's Capital

The Boshin War itself ended a few kilometers north of this district, at the star-shaped fort of Goryokaku, where Enomoto's holdout government surrendered on 27 June 1869 after the flagship Kaiten was defeated in the bay. The victors had little patience for the fort afterward: the War Ministry took it over, and by 1871 most of its buildings had been dismantled, their timber shipped off to help build the new capital of Sapporo. Soldiers drilled on the empty grounds from 1873 to 1897, before the city was given the site in 1913 and opened it as a public park the following year; it is now protected as Japan's only special historic site north of Honshu.⁸

Hakodate's own administrative rank rose and fell with the fire's smoke barely cleared. When the Colonization Commission was abolished in 1882 and its territory split into three prefectures, Hakodate became a prefectural capital in its own right — though, the city's 1935 history notes dryly, the wounds of the 1879 fire were still unhealed and trade was in a general slump when the change took effect. Emperor Meiji had already toured the town the previous year, in 1881, inspecting its courthouse, customs house and shipyard; the prefecture itself lasted only until 1886, when the government folded Hakodate, Sapporo and Nemuro back together under a single Hokkaido Agency based in Sapporo, leaving Hakodate a sub-prefectural office instead.²

The Second Fire and a New Public Hall

Fireproofing rules or not, Hakodate burned again. On the night of 25–26 August 1907 a fire that began in a soap factory on Higashikawa-cho, driven by a strong east wind, burned some 12,390 households according to the 1935 city history — by the account of the Kanemori warehouse company itself, nearly two-thirds of the town — destroying the British and Russian consulates, several schools, the prefectural sub-office and the town's own meeting hall along with it.²¹²

Two of the district's best-known landmarks rose directly from that fire's ashes. The merchant Watanabe Kumashiro, whose warehouse company had lost six buildings, ordered fireproof reconstruction at once; the new brick warehouses were finished in May 1909 and are the Kanemori Red Brick Warehouse that stands on the waterfront today. A few streets up the hill, the destroyed town hall and chamber of commerce were replaced by a new public hall: local fundraising fell short of the cost, so the merchant Soma Teppei personally donated 50,000 of the roughly 58,000 yen needed, and the building — designed by the ward's own engineer, Konishi Asajiro — was completed in September 1910. It has been a nationally designated Important Cultural Property since 1974.^{910 12}

The British consulate that burned in 1907 was already its third building on the site: an earlier one had burned once in 1866, and again in 1879. Its replacement took until 1913 to complete, designed under the British government's own Office of Works in Shanghai; the consulate closed in December 1934, and the city bought the empty building in 1940, using it for decades as a nurses' dormitory for the municipal hospital before designating it a city cultural property in 1979 and restoring it as today's museum, the Kaiko Memorial Hall, in 1992.¹⁶¹⁷

The Night of 21 March 1934

The worst fire came in 1934, and it began with weather rather than carelessness. From early afternoon a storm off the Tsugaru Strait blew ever harder; by the time flames broke out at 6:50 p.m. in a private house in Sumiyoshi-cho, gusts were already tearing roofs off buildings across the city, and the fire chief, Katsuta Yakichi, later broadcast that he himself was thrown against a utility pole by the wind and knocked down three or four times while trying to direct his crews. Six successive firebreak lines were set across the town's basin-shaped streets and broken one after another as the gale, gusting past 30 meters a second, carried burning debris ahead of the flames; Katsuta's own order to his division chiefs, to fight on independently if they lost contact with each other, closed with words he meant as a possible farewell: "do your best." The fire was not brought fully under control until roughly six the next morning.²³

The City of Hakodate's own figure for the dead is 2,166 — a toll in which burning was not even the largest cause: the city's breakdown records 917 by drowning, as people fleeing the flames went into the harbor and the sea in the cold of a Hokkaido March and could not get out again, along with 748 by fire, 217 by exposure to cold, 143 by suffocation, 29 by other causes and 112 more who died later after being taken in for care. Roughly 102,000 people were left without homes, out of some 22,700 households, and more than eleven thousand buildings burned across twenty-two fully destroyed neighborhoods and eighteen more partly burned; a social-welfare association's own disaster record, compiled within three years of the fire, gives closely matching figures for both the households affected and the pattern of deaths.²⁴⁶

Ferry's End, Preservation, and Reading the Ground Today

Hakodate's other great transformation came from the sea. For decades the Seikan ferries were the only way to move a train, a truck or a family between Honshu and Hokkaido; that service ended on 13 March 1988, the year the Seikan Tunnel opened beneath the strait instead. One of the last ferries, the Mashu-maru, is still moored at its original berth as a memorial ship, its bridge and radio room kept as they were on the final crossing.¹³

In the very same year, 1988, the city designated the hillside and waterfront around this dossier's study area — Yayoi-cho, O-cho, Suehiro-cho, Motomachi and part of Toyokawa-cho, about 14.5 hectares along a roughly 1.5-kilometer route from the harbor up to Motomachi Park — a traditional buildings preservation district; national recognition followed in 1989. Walk it today and the layers described above are still legible within a few hundred meters of each other: the fireproof stone and brick built under Kuroda's 1878 building code, the Orthodox church rebuilt after the 1907 fire, the Old Public Hall raised with Soma Teppei's money the same decade, and, on the quiet slope of Yayoi-cho, the flat ground where Kono Masamichi's box-shaped fort gave the whole city its name in 1454.⁷⁹¹¹¹⁴

Timeline

1454	Kono Masamichi builds a box-shaped fort at Usukeshi; the settlement becomes known as Hakodate. ^{5 14}
1811–13	The Golovnin incident: Russian and Japanese hostage-taking around Kunashiri draws in the Hakodate merchant Takadaya Kahei. ²
1850s	Town proclamations order residents to evacuate women and children and avoid provoking foreign crews when American ships are expected. ²
1859	Hakodate opens to foreign trade; consulates, including Russia's, follow within the year. ¹¹
20 June 1869	Fugitive shogunate troops set the "fugitives' fire," burning 872 households, weeks before their final defeat. ²
27 June 1869	Enomoto Takeaki surrenders Goryokaku, ending the Boshin War; the fort is later stripped for timber sent to Sapporo. ⁸
1869	Ezo is renamed Hokkaido and the town's name is respelled 函館. ⁵
16 Nov. 1878	A 954-household fire prompts Kuroda Kiyotaka to mandate fireproof stone-and-brick construction on the main streets. ²
6 Dec. 1879	A far larger fire burns 2,326 households and 31 public buildings before the 1878 rebuilding is even finished. ²
1882–86	Hakodate is briefly the seat of its own prefecture before Hokkaido's administration is recentralised in Sapporo. ²
25–26 Aug. 1907	Fire burns roughly two-thirds of the city, including both consulates and the town hall. ^{2 12}
1909–10	The Kanemori warehouses are rebuilt in fireproof brick and the new Public Hall, funded largely by Soma Teppei, is completed. ^{10 12}
21 March 1934	A wind-driven fire kills 2,166 people by the city's own count, most of them by drowning. ⁶
13 March 1988	The Seikan ferry service ends; the same year the Motomachi–Suehiro-cho preservation district is designated. ^{7 13}

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Motomachi–Suehiro-cho Traditional Buildings Preservation District** 元町末広町伝統的建造物群保存地区. Follow the roughly 1.5 km route from the harbor up to Motomachi Park; nationally protected since 1989, it holds most of the sites below within a few streets of one another. ⁷
- 2 Hakodate Orthodox Church, Church of the Resurrection** 函館ハリストス正教会（復活聖堂）. Rebuilt in 1916 on the site of the Russian consulate's 1860 chapel, where the priest Nicholas began Japan's first Orthodox mission in 1861; listen for the bell known locally as "Gan-gan-dera". ¹¹ [map](#) [🗺](#)
- 3 Kanemori Red Brick Warehouse** 金森赤レンガ倉庫. Fireproof brick warehouses rebuilt in 1909 after the 1907 fire destroyed their wooden predecessors; still standing on the waterfront they were built to protect. ¹² [map](#) [🗺](#)
- 4 Old Public Hall of Hakodate Ward** 旧函館区公会堂. A Western-style hall of 1910, largely paid for by the merchant Soma Teppei after the 1907 fire destroyed the previous meeting hall; a National Important Cultural Property since 1974. ^{9 10} [map](#) [🗺](#)
- 5 Site of Usukeshi Kono-tate, Yayoi-cho** 宇須岸河野館跡（弥生町）. The flat ground in today's Yayoi-cho where Kono Masamichi's box-shaped fort stood from 1454, giving the city its name; later magistrates' offices occupied the same site for centuries. ¹⁴ [map](#) [🗺](#)

6 Old British Consulate (Kaiko Memorial Museum) 函館市旧イギリス領事館（開港記念館）. The 1913 consulate building, designed by the British government's own Office of Works in Shanghai; a consulate until 1934, then a hospital dormitory until 1979, now a city-run museum recalling the era of Commodore Perry's calls and the port's opening to foreign trade. ^{15 16 17} [map](#)

Walk map



The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (1.2 × 0.9 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Stops not shown: 1. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- | | | | |
|---|---|---|--|
| 1 | Motomachi-Suehiro-cho Traditional Buildings Preservation District | 4 | Old Public Hall of Hakodate Ward map |
| 2 | Hakodate Orthodox Church, Church of the Resurrection map | 5 | Site of Usukeshi Kono-tate, Yayoi-cho map |
| 3 | Kanemori Red Brick Warehouse map | 6 | Old British Consulate (Kaiko Memorial Museum) map |

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2024



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2024 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2024*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

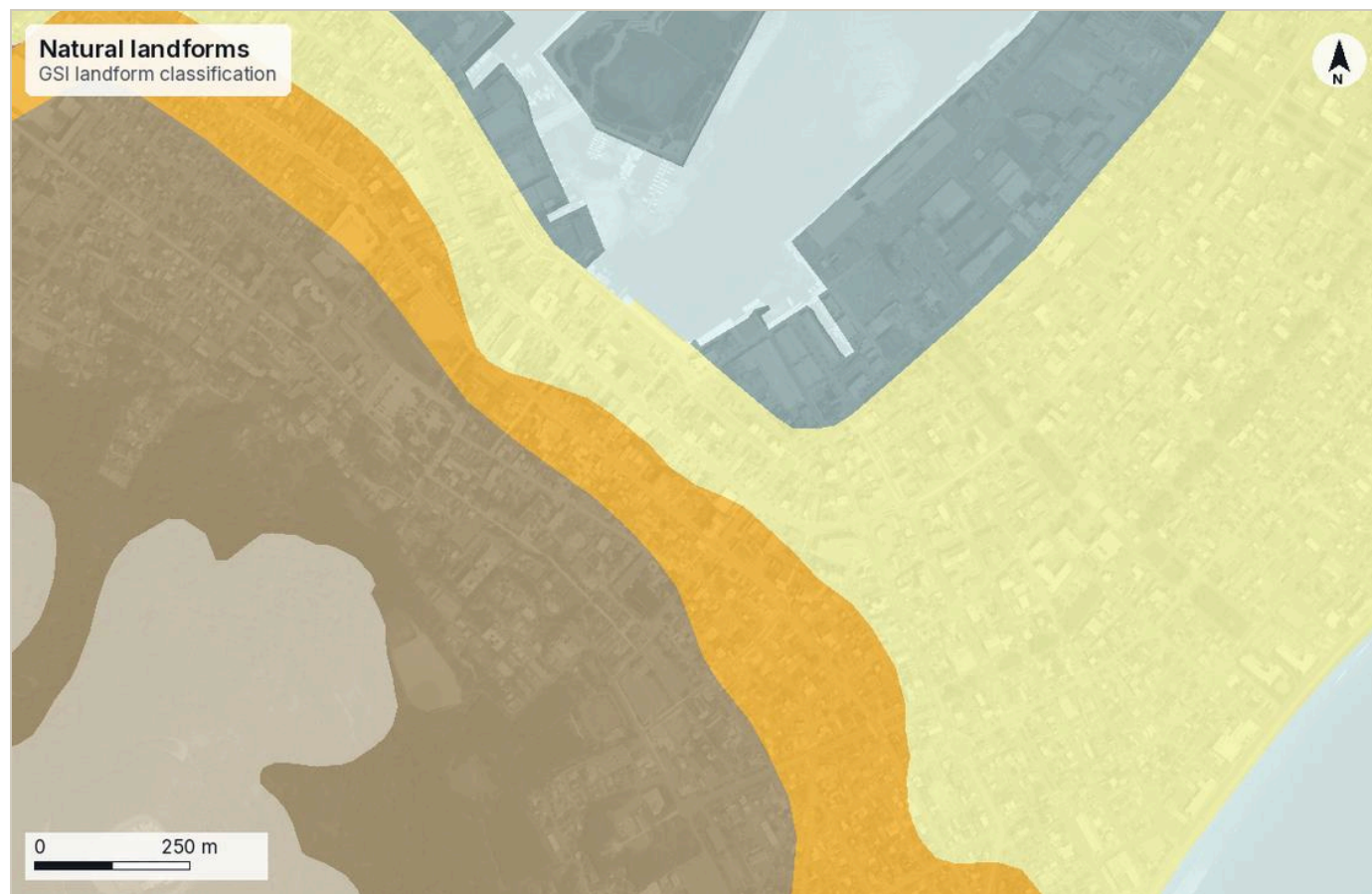
The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo*1, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Sandbars and dunes 34%	 Foothill deposits 26%
 Plateaus and terraces 11%	 Former water area 10%
 Water 10%	 Mountain and hill slopes 9.3%

What the main landforms mean

Sandbars and dunes (34%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Foothill deposits (26%). Gentler ground below mountains and scarps, built from debris brought down by slope failures and debris flows. Debris flows are possible in heavy rain; the ground is unstable and slopes may fail in earthquakes.

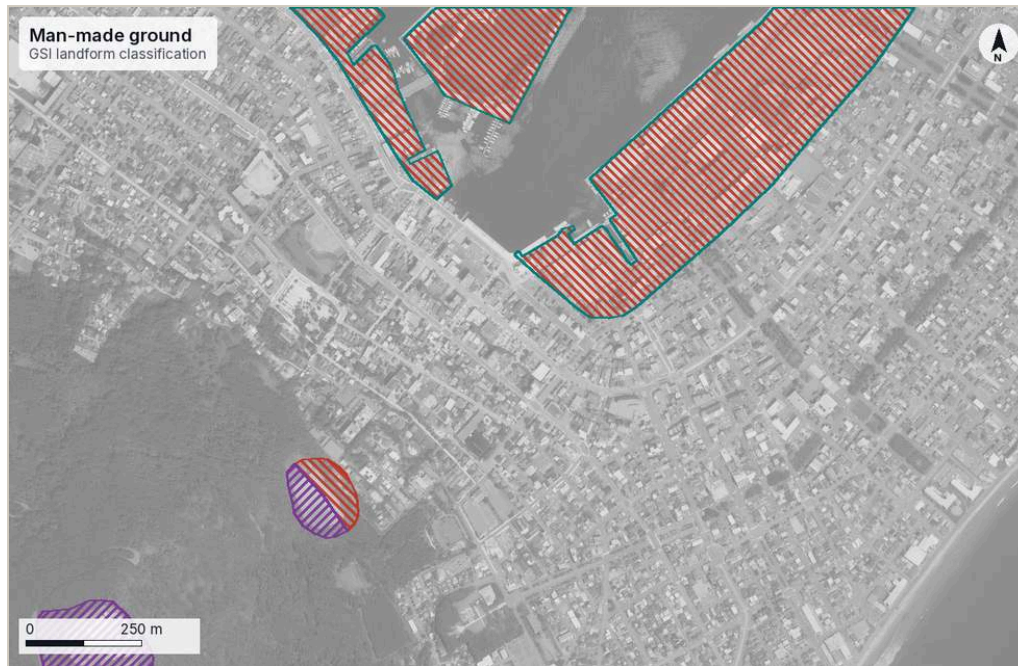
Plateaus and terraces (11%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Former water area (10%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Mountain and hill slopes (9.3%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

Man-made ground

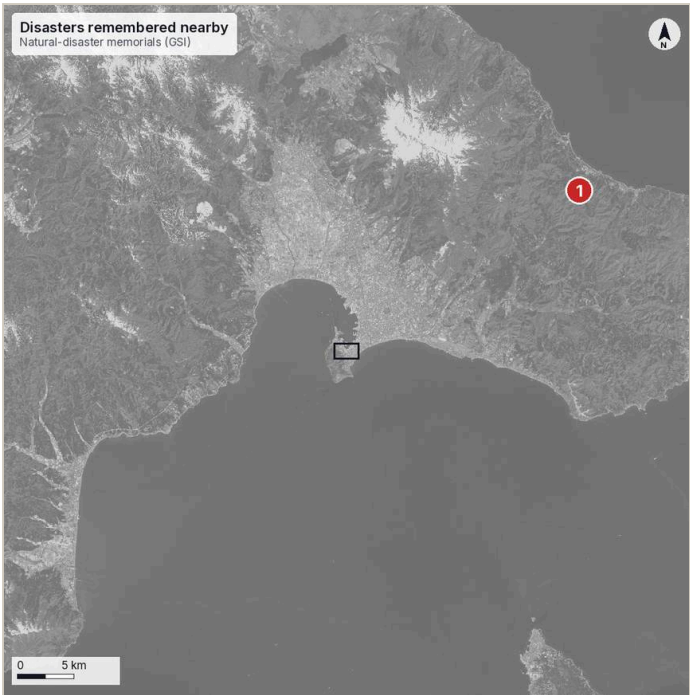
-  Filled and reclaimed land 10%
-  Cut ground 1.3%

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Filled and reclaimed land (10%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the victims of the 1973 torrential rain in Minamikayabe 遭難犠牲者慰霊碑	Torrential rain (24 Sep 1973) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1975	24.7 km

What the memorials record

1. Memorial to the victims of the 1973 torrential rain in Minamikayabe. Torrential rain fell on the southern Oshima Peninsula from the night of 23 September 1973 into the 24th. In the former town of Minamikayabe (now northern Hakodate) a record 383 mm caused floods, debris flows and slope collapses; the national highway was cut, 16 houses were destroyed, 8 people died and 11 were injured.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 函館区 (Hakodate Ward), 函館区史 [History of Hakodate Ward], 1911; NDL frames 24, 25, 47, 48. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763068/1/24> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Geography and gourd-shaped land; Ainu name Usukeshi; Mount Hakodate's geology and 1897 closure to artillery; the Takeda clan's unification of Wajin settlements and Ainu uprisings, used lightly for background.
2. 函館日日新聞社 (Hakodate Nichinichi Shimbun), 函館市誌 [Chronicle of Hakodate City], 1935; NDL frames 46, 73, 74, 77, 83, 92, 100, 101, 102, 421, 422, 423, 424, 433, 434. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1879893/1/421> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: 1899 land reclamation; the Golovnin incident; the 1850s black-ship proclamation; Boshin War fighting; Emperor Meiji's 1881 visit and the 1882-86 prefecture period; the full 1779-1934 fire chronology; Kuroda's 1880s fireproof-rebuilding order; the 1907 and 1934 fires in detail.
3. 函館消防本部 (Hakodate Fire Department), 函館大火史 [History of Hakodate's great fires], 1937; NDL frames 19, 20. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1257301/1/19> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Fire chief Katsuta Yakichi's own broadcast account of directing firefighting through the night of 21 March 1934.
4. 北海道社会事業協会 (Hokkaido Social Welfare Association), 函館大火災害誌 [Record of the Hakodate great fire disaster], 1937; NDL frames 52, 53. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1257280/1/52> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Official tallies of households and population affected by the 1934 fire and a cause-of-death breakdown, cross-checked against the city's modern figures.
5. 函館市の概要 [Outline of the City of Hakodate], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2014020600063/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The city's own account of Kono Masamichi's 1454 fort and the 1869 change of the city's kanji from 箱館 to 函館.
6. 函館大火 [The Great Fire of Hakodate], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2014012200615/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The city's official death toll (2,166) and cause-of-death breakdown for the 21 March 1934 fire, and its scale (area, buildings, households).
7. 函館市元町末広町伝統的建造物群保存地区の概要 [Outline of the Motomachi-Suehiro-cho preservation district], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2014022000335/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The preservation district's area, route, designation dates (1988 city, 1989 national) and the range of building types it protects.
8. 五稜郭の歴史 (箱館戦争から現在) [History of Goryokaku, from the Battle of Hakodate to today], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2014011700789/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The end of the Battle of Hakodate on 27 June 1869, the fort's dismantling for timber, its use as a drill ground, and its history as a park and special historic site.
9. 函館市重要文化財旧函館区公会堂 [Hakodate City Important Cultural Property: the Old Public Hall], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2014010800251/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Old Public Hall's completion in 1910, its architectural style, and its 1974 National Important Cultural Property designation.
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11. 教会の歴史 [History of the church], 函館ハリストス正教会 (Hakodate Orthodox Church). <https://www.orthodox-hakodate.jp/history-japanese>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1860 chapel built as the Russian consulate's annex, the priest Nicholas's 1861-72 mission, the 1907 fire and 1916 rebuilding, and the 1983 cultural-property designation.
12. 金森倉庫の生い立ち [The origins of Kanemori Warehouse], 金森赤レンガ倉庫 (Kanemori Red Brick Warehouse). <https://hakodate-kanemori.com/about/history>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Watanabe Kumashiro's 1887 start in the warehouse business, the 1907 fire's damage to the company, and the 1909 fireproof rebuilding.
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14. 宇須岸河野館跡 [The site of Usukeshi Kono-tate], 南北北海道の文化財 (Cultural Properties of Southern Hokkaido). <https://donan-museums.jp/archives/488>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Kono Masamichi's 1454 fort, its dimensions, its location in today's Yayoi-cho, and the site's continuous later use by the Kameda and Hakodate magistrates.
15. 旧イギリス領事館 (開港記念館) [Old British Consulate (Kaiko Memorial Museum)], 函館市 (City of Hakodate). <https://www.city.hakodate.hokkaido.jp/docs/2024020800097/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Confirms the building's current role as a city-run museum on the theme of the port's opening and Commodore Perry's calls.
16. 旧イギリス領事館 [Former British Consulate], 文化庁文化遺産オンライン、函館市教育委員会生涯学習部文化財課提供 (Agency for Cultural Affairs, Cultural Heritage Online; entry supplied by the Hakodate City Board of Education's Cultural Properties Section). <https://online.bunka.go.jp/heritages/detail/613953>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1913 brick consulate building's construction, the 1866, 1879 and 1907 fires that destroyed its predecessors, the city's 1940 purchase, its use as a hospital nurses' dormitory, and its 1979 city cultural-property designation.

17. 歴史 [History], 函館市旧イギリス領事館 (Old British Consulate of Hakodate). <https://www.fbcoh.net/history>, checked 2026-09-28.
Used for: The building's September 1913 completion and its designer (the British government's Office of Works, Shanghai); the consulate's December 1934 closure, the city's March 1940 purchase, the November 1979 cultural-property designation, and the museum's August 1992 opening.

Further reading

- 函館市史 (函館市, 通説編, 1980-90年代) — The city's modern, far more detailed official history, covering the Ainu era, the Matsumae domain and the treaty-port period at a depth this dossier could not match. <https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/search?cs=bib&keyword=%E5%87%BD%E9%A4%A8%E5%B8%82%E5%8F%B2> (print only)
- 函館沿革史 (福岡竹治郎・佐藤慶吉 著, 1899) — An earlier general history of the town, listed as open online; its NDL Lab record could not be read in this session (a server error on every request), so it is left for a future check rather than cited. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763066> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 函館案内 (小野寺一郎 著, 1902) — A period guidebook whose full-text search shows relevant hits on land reclamation and the Benten district, but whose NDL Lab record also returned a server error in this session. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763064> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 函館郷土史料目録：函館開港記念回顧展覧会出陳 (函館図書館編, 1935) — A catalog of historical materials shown at the 1935 port-opening commemorative exhibition; a guide to primary sources (letters, photographs, artifacts) held by the city library, not read in depth here. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1843301> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- Household-by-household or lot-by-lot records of who rebuilt what after the 1879 and 1907 fires, and how the fireproof-construction loans were actually used** — Hakodate City Central Library's local-history division and the Hokkaido Prefectural Archives (北海道立文書館). Request the library's local-history reference desk for post-fire reconstruction ledgers and old land registers (旧土地台帳) by lot number.
- Foreign consular correspondence on the 1907 and 1934 fires (each of which damaged or destroyed consulate buildings) and on daily life in the foreign settlement** — UK National Archives (FO series, Hakodate consulate), US National Archives, and Russian diplomatic archives for the 1860s Russian consulate. Search the UK National Archives' Discovery catalog under Foreign Office correspondence for Hakodate; equivalent searches for US State Department consular despatches.
- A fuller, victim-by-victim account of the 21 March 1934 fire, beyond the aggregate statistics used here** — The Hakodate Fire Department's own archive and the Hakodate Central Library's newspaper morgue (函館日日新聞, 函館毎日新聞, spring 1934). Request the fire department's historical records section and the library's microfilm reading room for the relevant weeks of both newspapers.
- Archaeological findings from the Usukeshi Kono-tate site and other 15th-16th century Wajin-Ainu contact sites beneath today's Motomachi** — Hakodate City's buried-cultural-property division and the Hakodate City Museum. Request published excavation reports (発掘調査報告書) for Yayoi-cho and neighboring blocks.
- Records of the Seikan ferry's wartime and postwar operations, including the 1954 Toya Maru sinking's effect on Hakodate itself** — JR Hokkaido's corporate archive and the Mashu-maru memorial museum's own collection. Contact the museum directly, and JR Hokkaido's public relations or archives office for company-history materials.

Caveats

- Household and casualty figures for the 1907 and 1934 fires vary slightly between the sources used here (the 1935 city history's 1934 death count of 2,165 versus the city's current official figure of 2,166, for instance); this dossier follows the city's own current figure where the two differ and names the 1935 source separately.
- Two internet-accessible NDL items likely to be useful — a c.1899 town history and a 1902 guidebook — returned server errors from the NDL Lab API on every attempt in this session and so were not read; they are listed in furtherReading instead.
- The 1454 founding date and the fort's dimensions rest on the city's own summary and a regional cultural-property register rather than on an NDL source read directly in this session.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. Positions of the walking stops: © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL), found with Nominatim. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.